

food budget and improve the quality of the food they eat is to join a food co-op. This is where several families combine to buy food in greater quantities. A co-op is not for everyone because it requires a periodic time commitment. But for those who are willing to apply their own time, it can be a way to greatly reduce their food bills.

Before moving on to the next category, one side note should be mentioned. If you eat out twice per week, it will not affect your food budget at all. Eating out is a part of your entertainment and recreation category—not food. The 16 percent allocated to the food budget presumes an average family in America eats out at *least* once per week anyway.

There are many ideas for marketing food stuffs at exorbitant prices that cycle through our economy from time to time. They catch on, then die out, only to be revived again when enough time passes that most of the buyers forget how they lost money earlier. Once such scheme is the freezer plan. I'm sure there are some perfectly legitimate home food sales companies, so I don't want to paint everyone with the same brush. But, in general, home food sales (usually called freezer plans) are the most expensive food purchases most families have ever made.

The way most home plans work is you commit to buy a given amount of your frozen foods from the company each month at a discounted rate. If you don't have a large freezer, you must buy one. The company will sell you one and finance it also. The pressure to buy the freezer is tremendous. It's usually presented as a failure to feed your family adequately if you don't have the freezer plan.

The catch here is that although the foods are good and often reasonably priced, they are foods that most families do not eat regularly. The average family ends up abandoning the plan in about four or five months and making freezer payments for the next four years.

The best advice I can offer is: stay with your menu plans and buy what you need, not what a sales company wants you to buy.